

Session 19: The Pattern of the High Place Sacrifice

Key Takeaways

- Noah's sacrifice—on the high place in front of the door of the divine refuge—is part of a larger literary pattern developing the theme of sacrifice in Genesis and beyond.
- God's response to Noah's sacrifice eliminates simplistic notions of God's wrath or God's mercy. It's both, not one or the other, and this drives the drama of the biblical story forward.

Noah's Sacrifice and the Design Pattern of Costly Commitment

Noah's sacrifice and the turn of God's will from judgment to generous blessing is a paradigmatic event in the Hebrew Bible. It sets the template for the unfolding drama as God continues to work with the seed of the woman, which will replay Adam and Eve's sin, generating conflict that leads to violence and a flood of divine judgment, creating an ultimate crisis of decision. Will humanity surrender what is most precious in order to release divine blessing into the world?

"As disobedience is decisive in the loss of life in Genesis 3, so obedience to the command is decisive in Genesis 12:1-3 and in the flood story. Noah's righteousness in 6:8-9 is a future reality that becomes actual only as Noah realizes it by his obedience 'before Yahweh' (7:1). When was this righteousness effected? [A]t the end of the flood when Noah's survival is first assured. Noah becomes by virtue of the acceptance of his sacrifice a *tsaddiq* in relationship to Yahweh. Here also the reason for the righteousness of Noah becomes clear: ... not simply for the salvation of Noah's immediate family, but the salvation of all humanity and living things. As Abraham received in Genesis 12:1-3 a command followed by a promise which incorporates a further command to be a blessing for all peoples, so Noah received a command followed by a promise that implies he functions as a *tsaddiq* for the salvation of humanity."

Clark, W. Malcom (1971). ["The Righteousness of Noah"](#). *Vetus Testamentum*, 21 (3). 273-274.

"But it is not simply that an extraordinary act of obedience by a righteous man [Abraham] leads to extraordinary blessing. It is that one man's obedience climaxes in an act of sacrifice and thus leads to extraordinary blessing ... The faithful obedience of Noah culminating in his sacrifices after the flood changed God's disposition toward sinful humanity. Similarly Abraham's obedience guaranteed the future of his descendants and that through them blessing should come to all nations."

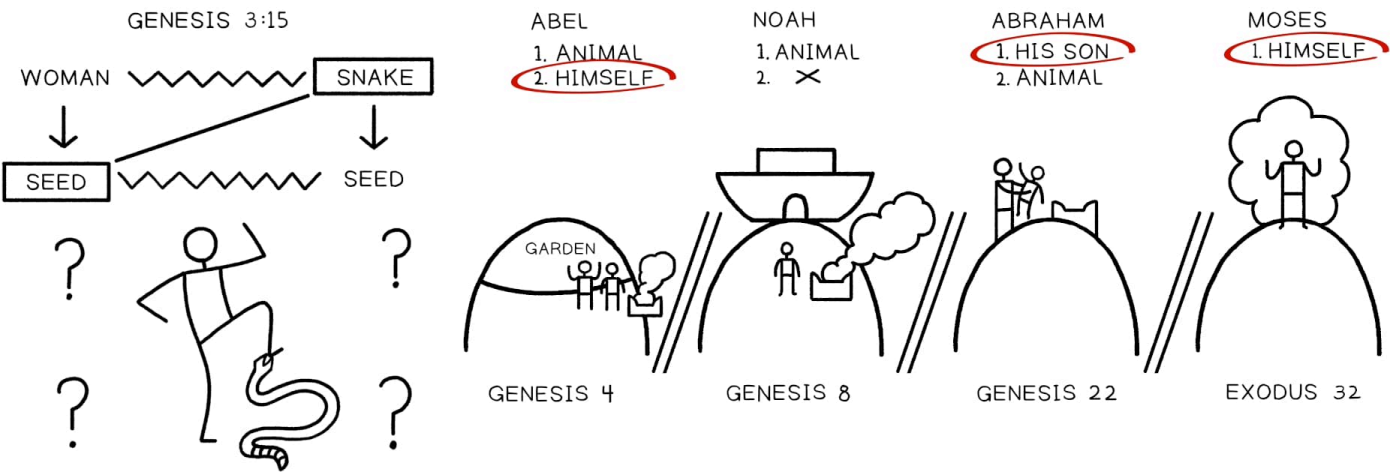
Wenham, Gordon (1997). "The Akedah: A Paradigm of Sacrifice." *Journal of Biblical Literature*, 116 (3). 102.

The Design Pattern of Costly Commitment Throughout Genesis and Exodus

The promise in Genesis 3:15—of a seed of the woman who will triumph over the snake but be struck in the process—sets the outline for a pattern of costly commitment that develops throughout the rest of Genesis and into Exodus.

- Abel on the mountain of Eden (Gen. 4:1-8)
- Noah on Mount Ararat (Gen. 8:20-22)
- Abraham and Isaac on Mount Morah (Gen. 22:1-14)
- Jacob loses Joseph (Gen. 37)
- Pharaoh loses his son in Egypt (Exod. 12:29-30)
- Moses at Mount Sinai (Exod. 32)

With each iteration of the pattern, we see small differences that begin to sketch the portrait of a chosen one who will come and give his own life on behalf of the many.



The Design Pattern of the High Place Sacrifice. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Reflection Question

How would you describe the way that this pattern of high place sacrifices ultimately leads to the anticipation of Jesus’ self-giving, atoning sacrifice?